Gregor Johann Mendel



Born Johann Mendel in 1822 on a farm in Silesia—then part of the Austrian Empire and now in the Czech Republic—Mendel studied philosophy and physics at the University of Olomouc (1840–43). At this time, he became interested in the work of Johann Karl Nestler, who was researching hereditary traits in plants and animals. In 1847 Mendel entered a monastery, where he was given the name Gregor. He then went on to study science further at Vienna University (1851–53).

When Mendel returned to his monastery in 1853, the abbot Cyril Napp gave him permission to use the gardens for his research into hybridization. Mendel himself became an abbot in 1868 and no longer had time for his experiments. Although he never received credit for his discoveries during his lifetime, he is widely regarded as the founder of modern genetics.

Key works

1866 "Experiments with Plant Hybrids," *Verhandlungen des naturforschenden Vereines in Brünn*

See also: Early theories of evolution • Evolution by natural selection • The role of DNA • The selfish gene